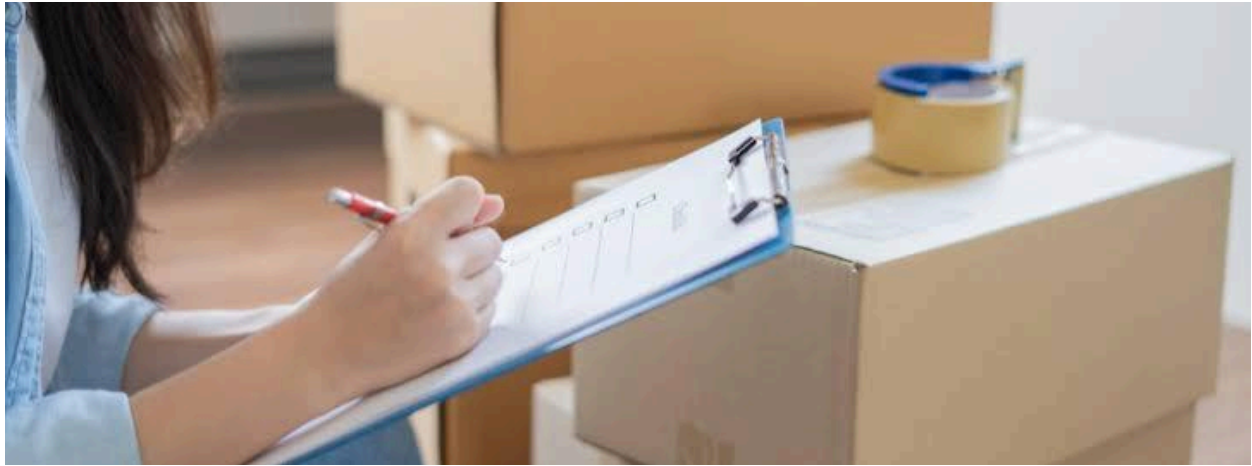


Financial Readiness One Step at a Time



Moving to RAF Lakenheath or the surrounding Tri-Base area is an incredible opportunity, but if we are being completely honest, the initial transit phase can be exceptionally expensive. Between upfront rental deposits, buying a UK-spec vehicle, and navigating a fluctuating exchange rate, your bank account is going to take a heavy hit before your OCONUS allowances finally pay out.

To ensure you don't face a financial crunch upon arrival, we have mapped out the essential banking, currency, and savings strategies you need to implement 60 to 90 days before your wheels touch down in the UK.



Foreign Transaction Fees: Your Plastic Strategy

One of the quickest ways to bleed money during your first month in England is by using your standard US debit or credit cards. Most traditional US banks charge a **3% Foreign Transaction Fee (FTF)** on every single purchase made outside the United States.

Before leaving the US, you should consider opening a credit or debit card that explicitly *waives foreign transaction fees*.

Recommended Options:

- **The Star Card (Exchange):** The Military Star Card features zero foreign transaction fees and is widely accepted at the RAF Lakenheath and Mildenhall Commissaries, Base Exchanges (BX), and on-base fuel stations. It's an easy, built-in option for your immediate on-base needs.
- **The Navy Federal Credit Union (NFCU) CashRewards or Flagship Cards:** Navy Fed is a staple for OCONUS moves. Most of their premium credit cards feature 0% foreign transaction fees and offer robust cash-back or travel rewards.
- **Chase Sapphire Reserve:** For those seeking a premium experience, the Reserve carries a \$550 annual fee (*waived for active duty and their dependents*) but completely offsets this with a \$300 annual travel credit that applies automatically to flights, hotels, or car rentals. It features 0% foreign transaction fees, complimentary airport lounge access (essential for those long PCS layovers), and industry-leading primary rental car insurance.
- **The Platinum Card from American Express:** Normally carrying a \$695 annual fee (*waived for active duty and their dependents*), this card is entirely free for active-duty personnel. It features zero foreign transaction fees and offers unparalleled travel perks.

Setting Up a Wise Account

When you rent a house in the UK, your landlord or letting agency will **not** accept an American checking account routing number or a US credit card for rent. You will need a way to pay in British Pounds (GBP) via a local electronic bank transfer (known in the UK as a BACS or Faster Payment). This is where **Wise** (formerly TransferWise) becomes an absolute lifesaver.

Wise is a multi-currency account that gives you an official **UK Sort Code and Account Number** without needing a physical UK address. It allows you to link your US bank account, hold money in British Pounds, and transfer money locally to UK businesses instantly. Best of all, Wise uses the real mid-market exchange rate, which saves you hundreds of dollars compared to traditional bank wire transfers or airport currency exchange booths.

How to Set Up Your Wise Account:

1. **Sign Up Online:** Go to the Wise website or download the mobile app. Sign up using your email or Google account.
2. **Verify Your Identity:** Because Wise is a regulated financial institution, you will need to upload a photo of your US passport or driver's license and complete a quick selfie verification.
3. **Open a GBP Balance:** Once your account is active, click "Open a Balance" and select **British Pounds (GBP)**.
4. **Get Your Local Bank Details:** Click on your GBP balance and select "Get Account Details". You will be prompted to deposit a small initial amount (around \$20) to activate them. You now have a functional UK account number and sort code to pay landlords or utilities.
5. **Order the Debit Card:** For a one-time fee, order the physical Wise debit card to your US address before you leave. You can use it the second you land to buy things in GBP with zero conversion penalties.



The Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) Trap

This is a major financial "gotcha" that stalls incoming personnel every single week. When you land in the UK, you will likely swap your US SIM card for a UK provider (like Vodafone, EE, or O2) or put your US line on a military suspension.

The moment you try to log into your US bank, credit card, or investment account from a foreign IP address in England, your bank's security system will trigger a fraud alert. It will attempt to send a text message verification code to your old US phone number. If that number is disconnected or the SIM card is sitting in a drawer, you will be completely locked out of your money.

Your Pre-Flight Action Plan:

- Log into every single financial institution you own *before* you depart the US.
- Update your security preferences. If the bank allows it, switch your Two-Factor Authentication (2FA) from "Text Message/SMS" to an **Authenticator App** (like Google Authenticator), **Email Verification**, or biometric fingerprint login.
- If you plan on keeping a US number active via a service like Google Voice or a low-cost carrier, ensure that specific number is updated across all accounts before you step onto the plane.



The Upfront Savings Cushion

Let's talk about raw numbers. Because of the *USD to GBP conversion barrier*, your US dollar does not stretch as far in the local economy. When £1 GBP equals roughly \$1.20 to \$1.30 USD, a £1,500 rental deposit actually requires nearly \$2,000 from your US bank account.

You should build a dedicated emergency savings cushion of **at least \$5,000 to \$8,000** specifically for the transition window. Here are ESTIMATES of where that upfront capital will go:

Expense Category	Timing / Requirement	Estimated Upfront Cost (USD Proxy)	Why It Matters / Hidden Nuances
Lodging	Due immediately upon arrival at base check-in.	\$2,700 – \$3,200	Air Force regulations require paying for up to 15 days upfront if staying less than a month.
First Month's Rent	Due the day you sign your tenancy agreement.	\$1,500 – \$2,500	Landlords legally require the first full month's rent before handing over the keys.
Tenancy Security Deposit	Due alongside your first month's rent.	\$1,500 – \$2,500	Capped by UK law at 5 weeks' worth of rent . This must be held in a government-backed protection scheme.
Temporary Car Rental	Daily or weekly until you buy a vehicle.	\$400 – \$800	Taxis around Suffolk are incredibly expensive. You will need a rental to view houses off-base.
Used Car Purchase	Within your first 2 to 3 weeks.	\$3,000 – \$6,000	Buying a reliable UK "runaround" or commuter car from the base Lemon Lot requires immediate cash or wire.

Financial Resources Directory

The Department of Defense, service branches, and local support agencies offer dedicated financial resources, low-interest emergency loans, and specialized counseling services.

Military & Family Readiness Centres (MFRC)

The MFRC houses Accredited Financial Counselors (AFC) who offer free, confidential budgeting assistance, investment guidance, and PCS cost-planning sessions. They also serve as the emergency relief dispatch point.

- **RAF Lakenheath MFRC (48th FSS):**
 - *Location:* Bldg 950
 - *Contact:* +44 (0)1638 523847 / DSN 226-3847

Air Force Aid Society (AFAS)

The AFAS is a private non-profit organization that provides interest-free loans, grants, or a combination of both for emergency travel, basic living expenses, temporary lodging distress, or vehicle repairs. Accessible directly through the Lakenheath MFRC offices. Airmen and Guardians can apply online or in person for standard emergency assistance or the "Falcon Loan" (a streamlined interest-free loan up to \$1,500).

Military Advanced Pay (Active Duty Only)

Active-duty service members can apply for an advance on their basic pay to cover the heavy upfront expenses of an OCONUS move.

- **Advance Basic Pay:** Typically allows you to request up to 3 months of basic pay, which is repaid automatically via monthly paycheck allotments over a 12-month window. *Note: This is an advance on your own future earnings, not free money, so use it cautiously.*
- **Advance Housing Allowances:** You can request an advance on your Overseas Housing Allowance (OHA) to cover upfront landlord security deposits and first month's rent. This is coordinated directly through the Base Housing Office (Bldg 950) and processed by Base Finance.

Civilian-Specific Financial Resources

Department of Defense (DoD) Federal Civilians do not have access to military aid societies like AFAS, but they have distinct statutory relocation lifelines.

- **Advance of Pay (Civilian PCS):** Under the Joint Travel Regulations (JTR), a newly assigned federal civilian traveling OCONUS can request an Advance of Pay of up to 3 months of their base salary upon arrival. This is designed specifically to offset TQSA delays and high upfront UK housing deposits. This must be requested through your hiring agency's Civilian Personnel Office (CPO) during in-processing.
- **Federal Employee Education and Assistance Fund (FEEA):** The national charity for federal civilian employees. FEEA provides interest-free emergency

loans to eligible GS employees facing unexpected financial hardships during a relocation or personal emergency. Applications are managed online at feea.org.